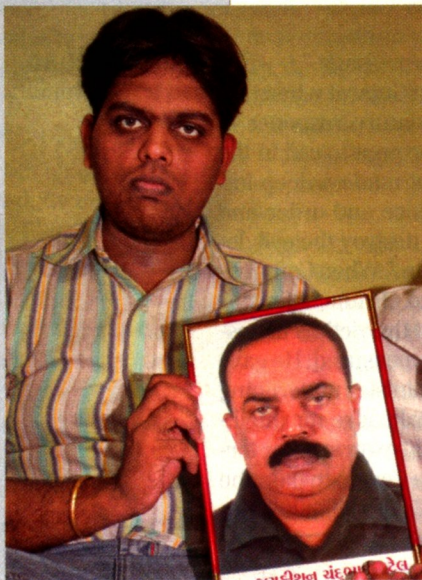


TALES OF TERROR

**JAIKISHEN
PATEL, 54,**
Social worker

Jaikishenbhai Patel, 54, and Jahwantbhai Patel, 58, were childhood friends. Residents of Asarwa village next to the Civil Hospital, they went to the hospital when local BJP leader Sanjaybhai Patel told them that some volunteers were needed at the hospital. Sanjaybhai escaped unhurt because he was standing at a distance when the blast went off while the duo died on the spot. Jaikishenbhai's son Nisarg has not spoken a word after his father's death. Sanjaybhai still can't overcome the fact that it was he who took them to hospital.



SHAILESH RAVAL



Modi, however, is in an unenviable position. Till recently, he was content in the knowledge that Gujarat had remained untouched by the terror network apart from the attack on Akshardham temple in 2002. The latest blasts have severely dented his image of invincibility but at the same time given him an opportunity to show his political mettle. If his anti-terror teams can solve the Ahmedabad blast case he will come out with his honour intact, considering that most such cases have remained unsolved elsewhere in the country.

For the country and its people, there is no such option. This is the first time that two cities in two separate states have been targeted on successive days. The Bangalore bombs may have been of low intensity and meant for psychological impact, but the Ahmedabad carnage and the bombs planted in Surat shows that terror has a new and deadlier face. Yet, even as the terrorists raise the stakes, the Government's

NARROW ESCAPE: Bomb squads defuse one of the 28 bombs found in Surat

response is knee-jerk and predictable: photo opportunities with victims lying on hospital beds, banal statements, and offers of monetary compensation. No declaration of new laws, no breakthroughs in the investigation, no introduction of better technology, no fresh effort for efficient intelligence gathering, better policing and stricter security measures. Police officials call it the 'three-day fever', referring to the fact that there is a flurry of activity for three days after a major incident, and then everything returns to normal.

That is a dangerous habit for a country seen as a soft state by terrorists who are now showing that they can strike when they want and where they want, and with an arsenal that is more sophisticated and deadlier, while the Centre counters with platitudes. The most telling sight was that of Home Minister Shivraj Patil, the man tasked with protecting India from domestic threat, looking more concerned about his white shoes and the rain puddles he and his leader Sonia Gandhi needed to avoid, than about the victims they had come to console. As a symbol of India's answer to the terror, there could not have been anything more depressing.

with Swagata Sen in Bangalore